tuning areas that really matter in English conditions. I've been working on playing late and adapting to the extra bounce and movement that their pitches usually offer. Shot selection becomes even more important there, so I've been consciously working on discipline early in the innings and then shifting gears once I'm set.

Q. How did your viral guitar celebration come about?

I play the guitar and I randomly started doing it during a photoshoot. It just stuck and soon became my thing. For a long time, I had this thought that when I score a hundred, I want to celebrate in a way that's 'me'. ■

—with Shail Desai



AFP



NET FLICKS
India's Smashing Affair with the Shuttle
By Akshay Lokapally & Vijay Lokapally
BLOOMSBURY
₹499; 250 pages

BOOKS ▼

The Great Game

Net Flicks **tells the fascinating history of Indian badminton**

Few know that the year 1947 was as momentous for Indian badminton as it is for the nation's history. Two stalwart shuttlers of undivided India, Prakash Nath and Devinder Mohan, took their rivalry to foreign shores for the first time at the All England Open Championship in Birmingham. As things unfolded, this mouthwatering quarterfinal clash had a bizarre end where nationalistic pride took precedence over individual sporting glory. Instead of sweating it out on court, the duo settled the tie with a coin toss to keep the winner fresh for the next round.

Nath went on to win the semifinal and became the first Indian to enter the final of the prestigious tournament. But ahead of the summit clash, news of riots back home in Lahore left him distressed. That final loss marked the end of a promising career and the early days of Nath's fight for survival. Nuggets such as these make *Net Flicks* an engaging read. It relives the eventful history of Indian badminton and is co-authored by veteran sports journalist Vijay Lokapally and his son Akshay.

Over the past decade, Indian badminton has hit its peak. The early days saw Ashwini Ponnappa and Jwala Gutta return with a bronze from the 2011 World Championships. The following year, Saina Nehwal clinched India's first badminton medal at the Olympics. Ever since, Indian shuttlers have regularly made the podium. The foundation of this success was laid by former players like Prakash Padukone and Pullela Gopichand. They knew the importance of world-class training and infrastructure, having struggled with it during their days as competing athletes. It was the case for most players of their generation, where talent and desire allowed them to look beyond the lack of opportunities. With few international tournaments coming their way, domestic rivalries took centre stage such as that between Nandu Natekar and T.N. Seth, followed by Padukone and Syed Modi.

OVER THE PAST DECADE, INDIAN BADMINTON HAS HIT ITS PEAK. THE FOUNDATION WAS LAID BY PLAYERS LIKE PRAKASH PADUKONE AND P. GOPICHAND

Those early days were definitive moments for Indian badminton and shaped the game as we see it today. While the narrative spans many decades and is comprehensive, it could have been a lot more engaging had it gone beyond individual profiles. ■

—Shail Desai